GRADIENT DEPRESSION · HUAWEI TECHARENA UK 2026 · CAREER SURVIVAL

mv-3

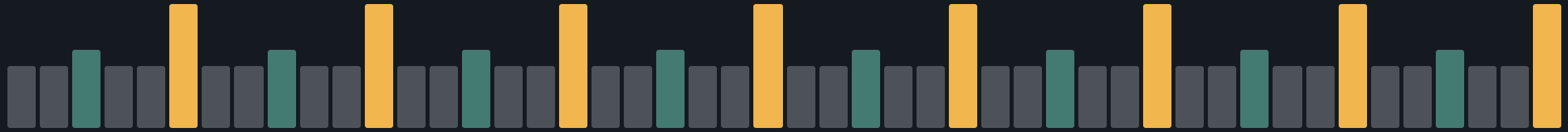
One Skill.
One reply per decision.

Final submission, Cut 3 · 1 November 2026

- **Q1** How we thought while designing
- **Q2** What the logs showed, and what we changed
- **Q3** Why no scripts or reference files
- **Q4** How general and robust it is
- **Q5** What Skills add to an agent, and where they fall short

THE TASK

A DeepSeek agent lives a 48-month career



month: 3 stories, effects hidden quarter: Energy and a main action review every six months: a chance to be promoted

Ways to lose

Never promoted, and dismissed · hidden risk blows up twice, a trust crisis · burnout or ruin

The only gauge of hidden risk

The tone of the monthly HR remark, as the Skill classifies it:

`friendly` `quiet` `uneasy` `frowning` `angry`

Three questions behind every decision

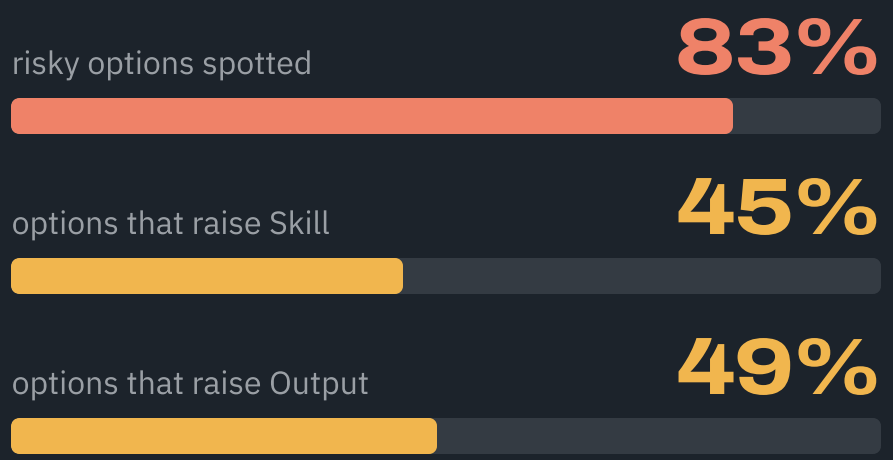
1. **What does this option probably change?**
   A reading guide in general words: what tends to move each stat and hidden risk. No event names, no answers.

2. **What does the career need now?**
   Fixed priorities: stay in the run, then win the next review, then grow.

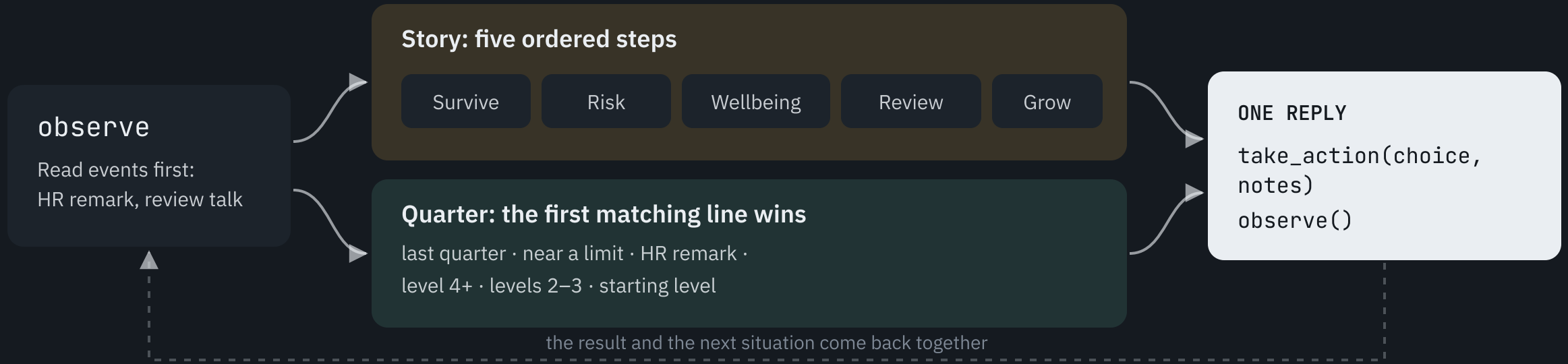
3. **Which rule applies in this phase?**
   Scope: a switch the agent computes, `Review in N`.

WHY QUESTION 1 IS THE HARDEST

Isolated-option tests with DeepSeek, before any Skill



The decision loop the Skill sets



EVERY NOTE STARTS WITH THE STATUS LINE: THE AGENT'S MEMORY AND THE SCOPE SWITCH

```
Review in N | Now S.. N.. O.. | Best S.. N.. O.. | Reviews here: 0
```

Review rules switch on only when N is 1 or 2 · Best resets on promotion · notes survive summaries

One Skill, with the essentials repeated in the manifest

skills/career-rules/SKILL.md — 7 sections

```
# Career rules
## What this Skill is for
## The 48 months at a glance
## Turn loop
## Status line
## Story decisions
## Quarterly phases: first matching line wins
## Near a limit: quick reference
```

manifest.json · instruction (excerpts) — repeats the essentials

> "Follow the career-rules Skill and `reread it whenever its rules are not in view`.
>
> `Decide stories only with its Story decisions and quarterly phases only with its quarterly list.`
>
> Turn loop: answer each situation with `ONE reply` whose tool_calls array holds exactly two calls … `drop options that may bury a problem` … `In the two months before a review, keep Network and Output at their best` … `From level 4 on`, every quarterly phase goes to Skill … `Every note is one line`."

With several Skills, the agent opened the one that looked relevant and missed rules in another. It reads the Skill early and then works from context, so the manifest carries what matters most.

Three cuts, three versions

CUT 1 · 27 OCT

t13-read-v4

64.75

official · 13th of 34

Reading guide, five story steps, review protection, a status line

CUT 2 · 30 OCT

mv-5r

45.44

official

One reply per decision; hidden costs named at the starting level only

CUT 3 · 1 NOV

mv-3

?

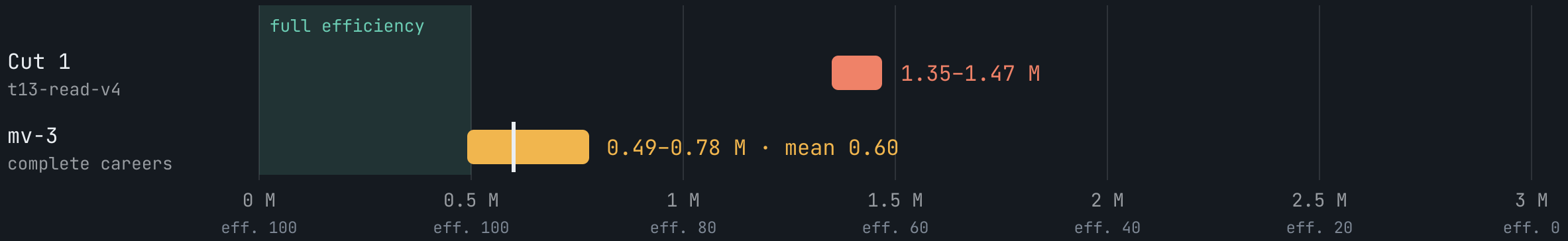
official score not known yet

Hidden costs named before every review; no extra manifest line

What the logs showed, and the rule it became

Promotions lost by **one point** of Network or Output, in the last story before a review	→	“In the two months before a review, keep Network and Output at their best this level and repair any loss at once” manifest · plus the Best value in the status line
Options that **sounded responsible**, like a private talk or a phased fix, carried hidden risk the model missed	→	“drop options that may bury a problem (private, anonymous, partial, later, hidden, skipping work to save time)” manifest · plus a strict mode when the HR remark is not friendly
The agent obeyed the review rule but **misread costs**: its notes treated a polite refusal as keeping Network	→	“Network falls whenever someone is let down, even politely or fairly” SKILL.md · Story step 4, “Read the hidden costs”

Every call resends the whole history



BEFORE · SEVERAL REPLIES PER DECISION

`reply → take_action(…)`

`reply → observe(…)`

each reply resends everything so far, so cost grows faster than the number of replies

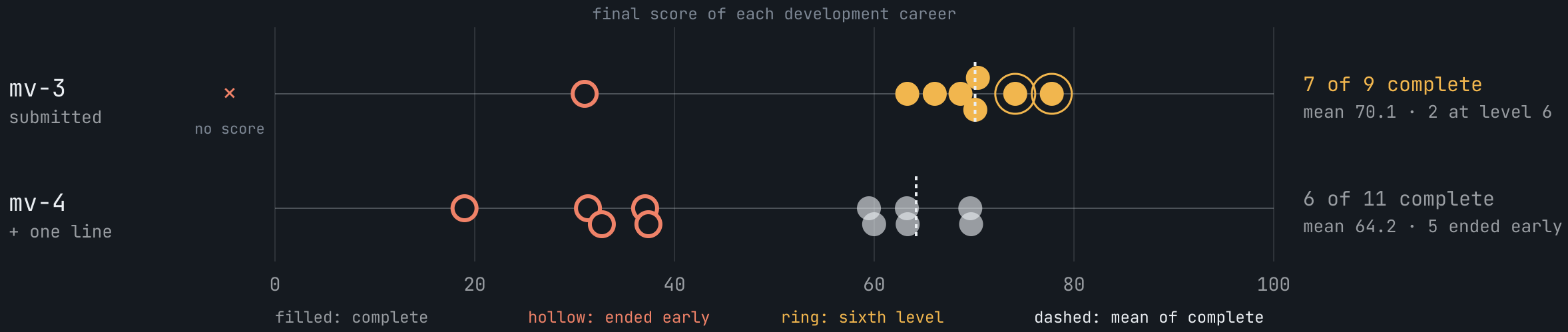
NOW · ONE REPLY, TWO TOOL CALLS

`tool_calls: [take_action(…), observe(…)]`

DeepSeek kept this pattern only when the Skill showed the literal shape of the reply

A fix that made play worse

mv-4 = mv-3 + one manifest line, added after a career was stopped by the runner when 21 replies carried no tool call: “`Never end a reply with text only … put the decision in the take_action call, not in prose.`”



Hypothesis, not proven: the line removes the short written reasoning the model needs when its provider does not reason privately. Development careers with the official runner and DeepSeek, not official scores.

Cheap tests misled us. Full careers did not

	WHAT THE CHEAP TEST SAID	WHAT FULL CAREERS SHOWED
Cut 2	A bank of recorded situations: the hidden-cost text adds risk at later levels, so keep it to the starting level	2 of 3 careers collapsed at the starting level; 45.44 officially
Cut 1 rules, rebuilt	Replays of the first months: leaves the starting level 79% of the time against 73%; top text score from two reviewers	3 of 5 careers dismissed at the starting level
A bolder variant	Accept one mild risk a month while the HR remark is friendly, to climb faster	Climbed no higher than mv-3; blow-ups in two careers

So we submitted the Skill of our best complete careers.

None, by choice

ADVISOR SCRIPT · A TEAMMATE'S LINE

One excellent career, too many early ends

Its best career reached the sixth level, but 3 of its 7 careers ended early, and complete ones used about 1.6 times the tokens.

SCRIPT WITH STATE · OUR RESEARCH REPLICA

Added nothing

What fails is reading the options, and a script reads them no better than the model that feeds it.

REFERENCE FILES

Not reopened

The agent read the Skill early and did not reopen supporting files.

Scripts that use only data from the current run were allowed by the organisers. mv-3 is one Skill and the manifest: no scripts, no reference files.

Built only on what the agent can see

The Skill relies on

- the tone of the HR remark
- review talks and warnings
- effects shown in the quarterly menu
- its own one-line notes
- the published calendar: a review every six months, with protection kept on if the talk comes late

No event titles, fixed answers or hidden thresholds. Our observations are marked as ours, and the game's signals come first. Turn loop verified with two model providers.

Known limits

- Perception: about one career in four still collapses, mostly at the starting level
- Third review at the starting level: won by **1 of the 11** careers that reached it, lost to hidden risk rather than missing stats
- The countdown assumes the six-month cycle
- Some providers sometimes write a tool call as text

Skills change how an agent works, not what it sees

Strong at

- Format: one reply per decision cut tokens per month to less than half on average
- Concrete quarterly directions are followed far more often than general goals

Weak at

- Perception: “protect Output” is obeyed, yet the model misses which option costs Output
- Scope: an earlier manual changed about 1 in 5 unrelated story choices
- One sentence can change how the model plays, as mv-4 showed

Skills give an agent priorities and discipline, not understanding.

WHY WE SUBMITTED MV-3

The Skill of our best complete careers

70.1

mean of 7 complete development careers out of 9; two reached the sixth level

<½

the tokens per game month of our first cut, on average

0

event titles, fixed answers or hidden thresholds in the Skill

Thank you.

Scores are from our development careers with the official runner and DeepSeek, except the two official cut scores (64.75 and 45.44).